mourning. Lorde writes in the final paragraph, “Hand-held the candles wink / in Berlin’s scant November light / hitting the Wall at 30 miles an hour.” Here she uses the word “Wall,” capitalized referring to the Berlin Wall as a proper noun. Lorde views Germany through rituals of commemoration and the time-space of a dream. She is wary of celebrations of triumph in light of the violence and uncertainty of the time. She comments on the nation’s transformation through modes of cross-border travel, alluding to going back in space and time, to reexamine the sort of deep divisions that remain traceable in the city.

In another poem, “Peace on Earth: Christmas 1989,” Lorde conjures the first holiday season after the Wall’s destruction, considering the rapid shifts in history that occurred following November 1989. She imagines two simultaneous drives: to account for the continuities of conflict and to lay bare an aspiration for peace, healing, and regrowth. Lorde writes of a “six-pointed star/ in the eyes of a Polish child,” as she is “lighting her first shabbas candle fading / into a painted cross on the Berlin Wall.”[35] The Star of David and shabbas lights convey a ghostly Jewish presence along the former border juxtaposed with a cross as a sign of commemorative loss. Together, they double as a call to heed lessons of the past, to slow the rhythms of historical time. Lorde uses spatial pausing in this instance again to slow the flow of the ideas and to double as an imagistic and physical reenactment of the act of “fading.” The word “fading” functions as an enjambed “apo koinou” to share meaning and forge connection across two lines. The appearance of the Berlin Wall in the subsequent line reminds us that the Wall is a canvas for expression and a site of post-1989 projection.

Further into the poem, Lorde juxtaposes and alternates between symbols of war and peace to convey the liminal time and space of reunified Berlin. For example, there are references to World War II–era European suffering and images of American patriotism, including excerpted lines from “The Star-Spangled Banner” and a transposition of text sent on emergency relief materials (“THIS IS A GIFT FROM THE PEOPLE OF THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA”), as well as a list of post–World War II and Cold War hot spots in Central America, South America, and Israel/Palestine (“Panama Nablus Gaza / tear gas clouding the Natal sun”). Moving between these places and historical references, her poem creates an invocation for diaspora and coexistence amid perpetual conflict.